attack on the Guantánamo base to justify an invasion. He was among the most consistent critics of the blockade option.[17]

But as negotiations on the Cuban crisis continued in Washington in the president's absence, Bobby positioned himself first and foremost as a spokesman for his elder brother. Endowed with a new sense of responsibility, he now argued in favor of a strike, preceded by a warning to Khrushchev. In this he reflected his brother's concern that a surprise attack like the one on Pearl Harbor would not sit well with the American public. As the deliberations continued through Friday and it became clear that the pro-blockade faction was winning the argument, Robert Kennedy's position evolved further, and he joined the majority, while still concerned that the administration was wasting its chance to get rid of Castro. On the morning of Saturday, October 20, Robert Kennedy reviewed a draft speech prepared by the president's adviser Ted Sorensen, which argued for a blockade. He decided that the time had come to call his brother back to Washington.[18]

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"GENTLEMEN, TODAY WE'RE GOING TO EARN OUR PAY," KENNEDY told the members of his Cuba advisory committee when he joined them upon his return to Washington. "You should all hope that your plan isn't the one that will be accepted." The first to report was Ray Cline, the CIA deputy director for intelligence. "We believe the evidence indicates," said Cline, "the possibility that 8 MRBM missiles can be fired from Cuba today." In the course of the previous week, they had learned about the medium-range ballistic missiles stationed in Cuba, then about preparations to place intermediate ones; now it was clear that some of the missiles in place were ready to be fired.[19]

After listening to Cline's report, John Kennedy opened the discussion. While most of the group favored a naval blockade, individual views about its purpose and hopes associated with it varied. Rusk believed that it would buy time and keep options open for further action, whatever it might be. McNamara hoped that it would present an opportunity to start discussions on exchanging the Soviet missiles in Cuba for the American ones in Italy